The Trail to the Sacred Mountain:

A Handbook for an Adult Wilderness Rite of Passage

By Steven Foster, PhD and Meredith Little

Founders, School of Lost Borders

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To all those we prayed for at basecamp,
and to all those who returned
from the sacred mountain
to "perform their vision on earth
for the people to see."

-Steven and Meredith

In ie tlecujlixquac, in ie tlamamatlac.
Already at the edge of the fire, already at the stairway.

-Nahuatl saying

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Our heartfelt gratitude and thanks to all those who contributed, each in a unique way, to the spirit and substance of this rites of passage ceremony as discussed in these pages. We particularly want to thank Virginia Hine, our spirit guide, for the old Handbook, written while she was still alive and used for so many years. Without this seed, the present Handbook would never have sprouted and grown.

We want to acknowledge those individuals whose faithful commitment to the ceremony as instructors and guides has again and again demonstrated the practicality of the process discussed here (after 40 years, not a serious injury to an initiate) and whose creative insight and leadership has enriched the ceremonial content. Special thanks to Linda Gregory, Jack Crimmins, Marilyn Riley, Jennifer Hine-Massey, Ron Pevny, Drew Pratt, Sunwater, Adele Getty, John Morris, Theresa Koke, Beau Leonhart, Ruth Leveton, Annie Prutzman, Ark Bodin, Michael Bodkin, Miguel Batz, Ruck Rucker, Paul Berman, Marilyn Mountain, John Davis, Emerald North, Betsy Perluss, Silvia Talaveras, Scott Eberle, Ruth “Roo” Wharton, Petra Lentz-Snow, Angelo Lazenka, Pedro McMillan, and many many others.

We also want to honor and thank our teachers, both formal and informal ones, for the time and care they took to answer our questions and to help us find what we were looking for, even after we had stumbled past it in our trust and innocence. Heartfelt gratitude to Virginia Hine, Hyemeyohsts Storm, Rocky Storm, Sun Bear, Wabun, Shawnodese, Robert Greenway, Howard and Sue Lamb, Mike Groza, Evelyn Eaton, Grandpa Eagle, Tom Pinkson, Rolling Thunder on the Mountain, Brant Secunda, Jonathan Swift- Turttle, Ralph Metzner, Larry Dean Olsen, Steven Kent, M.D., and Mike Riley, EMT.

Meredith Little, Founder
Lost Borders Press, 2024

Note: This handbook is an ongoing project. It will never be completed or fully edited. Our intent is to maintain the integrity of its original vision, including the unique voice of founder Steven Foster, while also making room for new voices and the changing times. This most recent version has benefited greatly from the contributions of Yanitsa Rodriguez, Kim Moriyama, and Timotéo Montoya, as well as many of the guides at the School.

Selene Foster, Editor
Lost Borders Press, 2025

CONTENTS

PREFACE
Indigenous Acknowledgement
Cultural Relations
Solidarity and Accessibility

INTRODUCTION
The Crises and Transitions in Modern Times
The Collective Crises
Why Do You Want to Participate in a Rite of Passage?
The Initiation Ceremony
The Process
Severance/Threshold/Incorporation

STAGE ONE: SEVERANCE
Severance
The Day Walk

STAGE TWO: THE SACRED MOUNTAINS OF THE THRESHOLD
The Threshold
- Finding Your Place on the Earth
- Food
- Walking Lightly on the Earth
- Talking with the Wind
- Dreaming
- The Death Lodge
- The Purpose Circle
- Asking for a Vision
- Emergence (Giving Birth to Yourself)

STAGE THREE: INCORPORATION
Incorporation (The Return)
Ceremonies of Incorporation
The Trail Ahead

PLANNING YOUR OWN CEREMONY
Questions

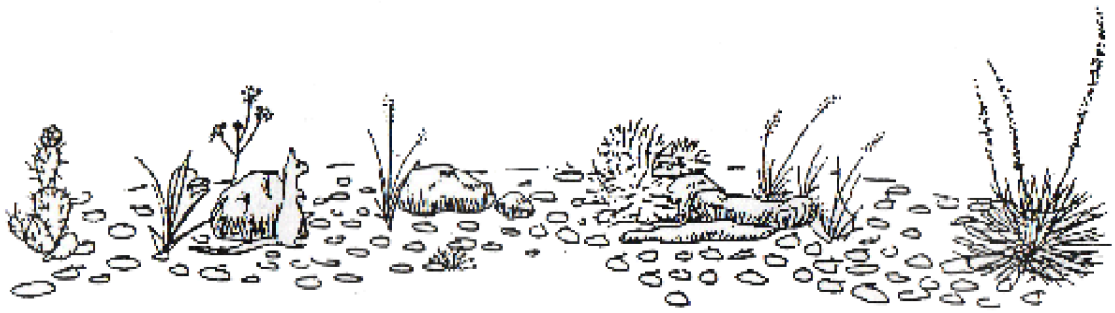
PREPARATION
Equipment List
Weather
Flora and Fauna
Terrain
Physical Preparation

APPENDIX
Returning Early from the Threshold
Fees and Payments
Wilderness Ethics Statement

INDIGENOUS ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

We honor and recognize the native and indigenous people on the many lands on which we sit in ceremony together. They are the original stewards of the land, water, plants, and animals. We acknowledge the painful history and the many crimes against the original inhabitants in this, and other regions of this continent perpetrated in the interest of western european supremacy and expansion.

It is a profound privilege that we can participate in these rites of passage and rejoin the ceremonies and rituals that have been passed down through generations by the peoples of many lands. For many, these ceremonies are more than a personal journey - they are a way of reclaiming an ancestral connection to a land, spirit, and culture that had been violently threatened. There are countless individuals whose lineages were fractured by colonization, and whose ancestral practices were disrupted, forgotten, or forcibly erased. The path to healing and rediscovery is not so easy to tread. The privilege we hold to be a part of sacred rituals is a testament to the resistance of those who preserved these traditions against all odds. It is a reminder of the privilege we have to reconnect and the responsibility we have to honor the ancestors and original stewards of all the lands on this earth, who still guide us from afar.



CULTURAL RELATIONS

As an organization, the School of Lost Borders is committed to introducing participants and trainees to the important history of First Nation peoples in the many places where we hold our programs. We acknowledge much of our work, including our headquarters, are in Payahuunadü, the ancestral, historical and contemporary homelands of the Nüümü and Newe peoples.

We make it a practice to look for ways to say thank you, not only to the land, but to the community. Some guides contribute time, energy, and funds to indigenous organizations as well as other efforts focused on social justice, healing, and the restoring of right relations.

We strongly encourage people to learn about their own ancestry and roots, knowing that ceremony comes through relationship and deep connection with people and place. At the same time, we acknowledge that it is a privilege to know, and have access to records of one's own ancestry.

With that, our work is focused on offering all people an opportunity to experience belonging on this earth. To feel a part of, and not separate from nature. As this relationship is remembered, marked and celebrated, we hope that all cultural identities and traditions can co-exist a bit more peacefully.

We are committed to actionable change, social justice, and regenerative relationships with all beings and the land.

*

We honor the Indigenous peoples of all of the lands where we work.

*

We are committed to and engaged in active listening and learning and our work is ongoing. We welcome input and feedback and will continue to share as we go.

SOLIDARITY AND ACCESSIBILITY

We at the School of Lost Borders are aware that our work exists within a context of challenging and often painful issues related to justice, equality, diversity, and inclusion. These issues touch on race, ethnicity, gender, class, and other categories. They also touch on our relationships with the lands where our programs take place and the complex cultural relations with the traditional peoples of those lands.

We are in deep exploration about how to understand and contribute to healing from these issues. We remain committed to welcoming all those who are called to our programs and to doing our part to remove any barriers to responding to this call.

While the programs at the School of Lost Borders are inclusive to all people, we recognize the need to have programs anchored within particular communities, such as Queer specific programs offered for the LGBTQ2IA+ community, BIPOC, veterans, women, men, youth, and elders. In these spaces, there is often a strong container of shared experience, which provides added safety and can be very healing.

We know that similar identity-specific programs are needed for BIPOC and other identity groups not currently served in this way by the School. We are working towards wholeness, creating more access and more representation within our own guide collective, and more inviting spaces for systematically marginalized communities in our organization and work.



INTRODUCTION



Deep in your heart you *know* whether or not you want to experience a rite of passage. Already you feel the ancient stirring within you. The time has come. You must go onto the land, onto the Earth, and seek vision, understanding and strength for yourself and for your people. Truly, the survival of the social order depends on *your* providing visionary leadership, on *you* as an active force working for the welfare and growth of the people.

The individual human spirit must be renewed and revitalized by the quest for vision. Deep in your unconscious, where you hear the voices of your ancestors, you *know* that the time has come to leave everything behind and go alone to the sacred mountain. You are ready to accept the responsibility that accompanies this choice.

The definition of *vision* is the faculty or state of being able to see, or the ability to think about or plan the future with imagination or wisdom. It is not necessarily a grand, magnificent, or showy awakening.

It most likely will not come to you as a sudden burst of light.

Look carefully at your expectations. The Greek god Prometheus stole fire from the sacred altar on Olympus and was condemned to eternal torment. What you take without earning it will probably die in your heart. Do you hope to take a recreational dance through a phantasmagoria of altered states? If so, you will be unable to find a comfortable place to sit. Are you looking for a vivid hallucination or two? If so, you will forget what you saw within a few months. Are you expecting a "quickie" self-transformation, hoping you won't have to work too hard? If so, you will return from the sacred mountain feeling cheated, puzzled, and no more prepared to serve your people than you were before.

Many there are who quest for vision. Few there are who return to actually demonstrate the reality of their vision for the people of their world. To every initiate, the charge is the same: to shoulder the vision of "doing" and to live your myth.

THE CRISES AND TRANSITIONS OF THE INDIVIDUAL IN MODERN TIMES

No human escapes being human. We must all face the ecstasy and the agony of human experience. Life is filled with transitions; growth is characterized by change. As Octavia Butler says, “All that you touch, you change. All that you change, changes you. The only lasting truth is change.”

Everyone’s journey through life, including experiences of growth and maturity, unfold at different times and in unique phases. But it can be useful to use the “traditional” phases of life as a lens through which to understand our unique journeys.

Humans must pass from one life stage to another. We are born from the womb into infancy. We are weaned from infancy and brought into the world of childhood. We pass from childhood into adolescence, from adolescence into adulthood. We make our way through the adult passages, facing predictable crises at middle age and "retirement." With aging comes preparation for dying, and finally, the ultimate passage of death.

Since ancient times, individuals have stood at the threshold of these life changes. In traditional cultures, these transitions were and are celebrated by rites of passage and ceremonies of initiation. Without these ceremonies, individuals could not have understood or interpreted their life experiences, nor could they have been capable of assuming the social responsibilities and privileges required by these changes.

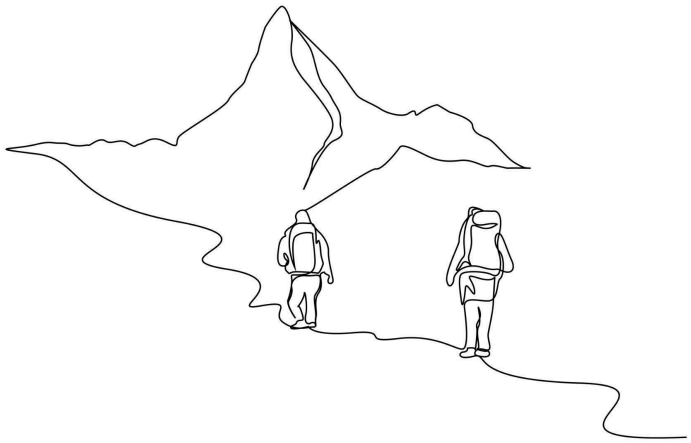
To acknowledge just a few of the Indigenous peoples whose wisdom can be drawn upon: the Diné (Navajo), Lakota Sioux, Chippewa (Ojibwe), Maasai, Māori, Sateré-Mawé, Inuit, Apache, Celtic…the list goes on.

Nowadays, traditional life passage ceremonies are not a part of the lives of most people. The thickening of the wall between humans and their natural environment has contributed to the loss of traditional ceremonies of life passage. The careful, ritual footprints left by our ancestors have been engulfed by the traffic of modern civilization.

Our modern human experience includes a multitude of "crises," "accidents," "upheavals," and other traumatic life changes that ask us not only to survive them, but to understand their meaning and to grow thereby. How many times in our span of years are we called upon to uproot and transplant, to let go of the old and embrace the new, to end it and go on, to plow under and sow seed, to cease being ignorant and find out, to die and be reborn? How many times will we move from one place to another, change our work or vocation, lose or be separated from a lover or friend, mourn the death of a parent, conceive, give birth to, miscarry, or abort a child, be devastated by a natural disaster, drop into suicidal depression, survive a near fatal accident, lose our limbs or sensory functions, do violence to or have violence done to us, become parents, grandparents or step-parents, enter the armed forces, embark on a long journey, become addicted to a drug, or burn out on the job?

There is no way to ascertain to what extent the loss of meaningful rites of passage has crippled the growth of modern individuals through the passages and crises of life in modern culture. Those who have a strong value or myth system, i.e., a way of finding meaning in their experience, most easily survive these passages. There are many individuals, however, who do not have, or cannot refer to, an adequate value or myth system. People often remain in crisis over extended periods of time, unable to make the passage from the old world (the past) to the privileges and responsibilities of the new (the future). Bereft of the means of understanding what has happened, or is happening, caught up in a crisis one cannot leave behind. It consumes them, stuck in the passage and swallowed by it. Bruised, battered and bewildered emotions rage unrestrained. Because the traditional ways of passing through crises are not available, individuals must either find their own way, sometimes with the help of others, or succumb to the perils of the passage.

This time on planet Earth is marked by the specter of what many call “the metacrisis” or “the polycrisis.” Everywhere we look, whether that gaze is regional or global, environmental or societal, the challenges are many and existential. The call for solidarity is profound. Time in wild nature and in community is indispensable. Much of what is spoken of above can be applied to the struggles of navigating the broader crises and transitions at work in our communities today.



WHY DO YOU WANT TO PARTICIPATE IN A WILDERNESS RITE OF PASSAGE?

It is very important that you are certain why you want to participate. If you are not clear about what you are looking for, you will not find it.

What passage, crisis, or transition do you find yourself in? What life event do you seek to celebrate, mark, or leave behind? Have you come to a door marked "fresh beginning" or a door marked "conclusion?" If you cannot give yourself a clear reason for going to the wilderness alone you should question again. If your intention is to heal and you do not look more deeply into the source of your suffering, the trip may be for naught.

Your reasons for undertaking this ceremony do not have to be significant to anyone else but yourself. In fact, others may think you have lost your way. This reaction from others has been felt by the healers, original wisdom keepers, visionaries and prophets of old and new.

In their wisdom, the sacred ancestors of many peoples designed rites of passage in such a way as to lead you to discover within yourself the healing vision you seek. The very feelings that tug at you, pulling you toward ceremony, evidence the ancient way of knowing that exists in you. The ceremony evokes this knowing, infuses your life with meaning, and prompts you to find the answers that you seek.

If you have turned toward this urge to "get away from it all," to sever from a former world and find a place of vision and self-empowerment, then you have taken the first step toward participation in this ancient and sacred ceremony.

It is essential that you take this step with the confident recognition that you are going away only so that you can return and assume the responsibilities of your new place in the world.

Over the years, thousands have gone out to the desert, the mountains, the plains in a similar way, alone, fasting, praying, seeking connection to self, others and the earth. Many were in the midst of life crises or were passing from one life stage to another. Many went to clarify and strengthen who they were in their lives, their families, their work and their communities.

There is no right reason to embark upon this path.

The reasons why these and other individuals left everything behind and went to the sacred mountain indicate the continued relevance and adaptability of this traditional rite to the modern world.



THE CEREMONY

On the mythical plane, this ceremony is an initiatory journey, a symbolic ordeal, that occurs in a sacramental region of natural power wherein the initiate encounters "demons" or "spirits" -reflections of his/her/their life or karma as mirrored by the natural cosmos.

On the physical plane the participant lives in a sensitized state of bodily awareness and feels the connection they share with the elements and living things of the natural world. Bodily states of emptiness and weakness often give rise to emotions and fears concerning personal survival on many levels. The body /psyche responds to the challenge and furnishes the individual with unexpected sources of strength and vitality.

Put another way, this is the quintessential transpersonal experience; by spending time alone in the wilderness our sense of identity or self extends beyond the individual or personal and encompasses wider aspects of humankind, life, psyche, or cosmos.

This new inner knowledge helps to heal the acculturated split between what we hold sacred (that which is set-apart, awe inspiring, and/or worthy of devotion) and profane (mundane everyday concerns), and is the basis for a new recognition of our physical/spiritual place on this land.

Perception of our true place in nature, however, is not possible without taking the first, hesitant, steps across the margin of our experience. This ceremony provides an ancient, time-tested way of taking those first steps:

THE PROCESS

This rite of passage is an experience of symbolically passing from one life stage to the next. The individual moves from the state of "letting go" to the state of "beginning." This passage between the two worlds is often referred to as a womb or a grave. The rites and ceremonies attendant on this passage were many and varied, depending on culture. Invariably, they provided for the furtherance and preservation of the social order among the people or nation.

Despite the variety of rites evolved over thousands of years by diverse cultures, the inherent framework is common to all rite-of-passage ceremonies, including this one. You will be led through a three-stage process.

SEVERANCE / THRESHOLD / INCORPORATION

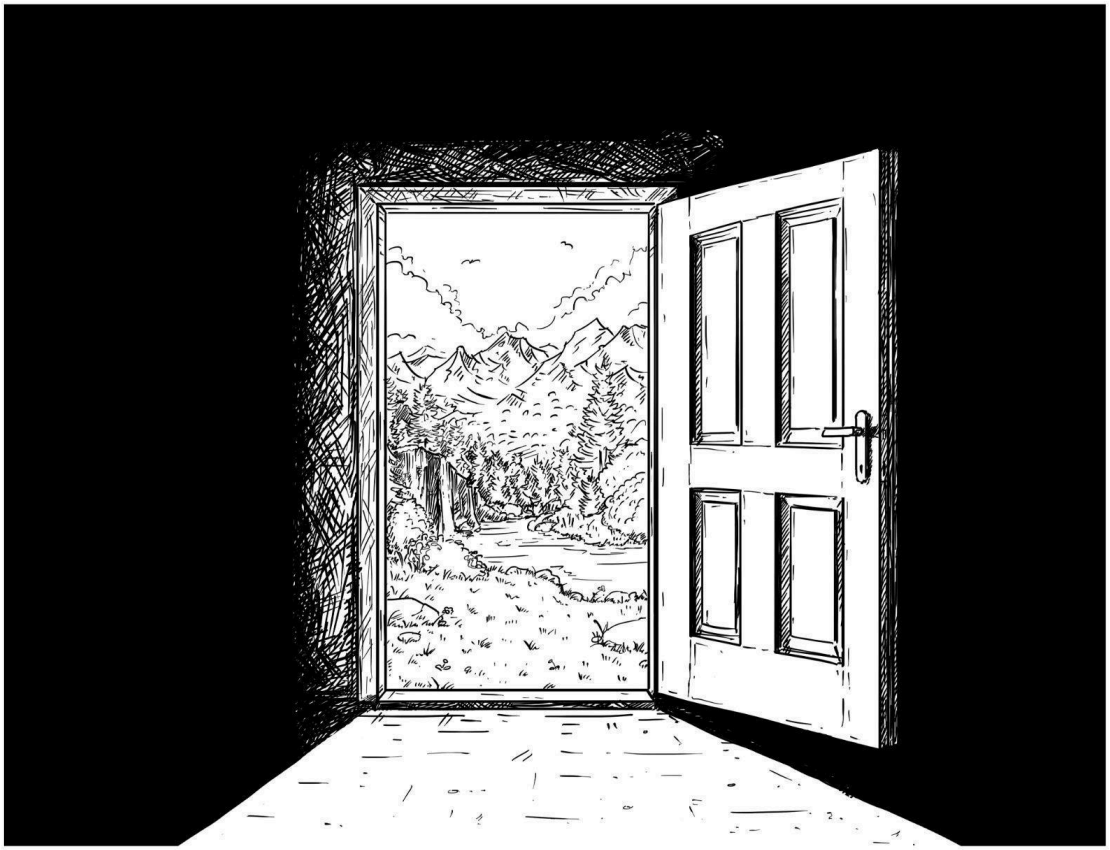
SEVERANCE. Over a period of time, you will prepare to break from the former world, to leave everything behind. At the appropriate time, you will separate yourself from previous concerns, be removed from your regular routine and head out onto the land.

THRESHOLD, or the "sacred world." You will enter the threshold (or passage) when you step across the limitations of your former life and begin the time of testing. Here in the threshold you may be faced with any number of challenges, or you may feel deeply nourished. You may experience both. No matter your experience, you will make your "last stand," dying to the old and embracing the new.

INCORPORATION (literally, “taking on the body"). Returning from your journey, you will assume the task of bringing your self, your vision, your understanding, into the gross body of the world - for the benefit of your people.

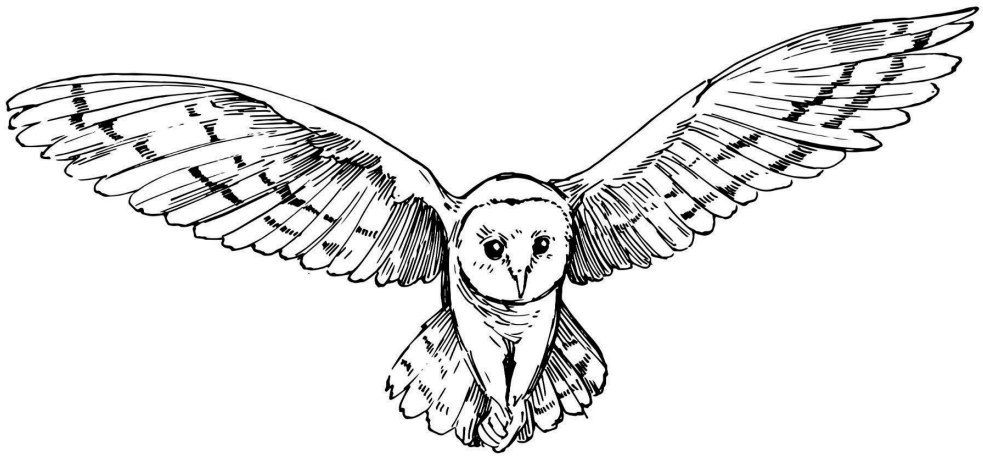
As you stand rooted in the soil, and reach out, like a plant into the light of the sun, you will also seek to know your place among all the peoples of the earth. You will greet all who have journeyed before you, regardless of their beliefs. Every thought, emotion, prayer, dream, or song will resonate with the power of your ancestors. Through you, and the ceremony you perform, your grandparents from the beginning of time will reach ahead to the fulfillment of our collective vision -- and the ever-evolving interdependency of all the peoples and beings of the earth.

Although this same three-stage process underlies all such passage ceremonies, this ceremony is as expansive and diverse as the people who have come to participate. It would be wrong to assume that there is only one "correct" ceremony. It will be up to you to navigate your needs as they pertain to severance, threshold, and incorporation.



STAGE ONE:

SEVERANCE



SEVERANCE

"Nothing can be sole or whole/That has not been rent," wrote W.B. Yeats. Former limitations must be torn down in order to establish new boundaries. Death must precede new birth. If we want to make a new start, we must say farewell to the old way to have a clear road into the new. Now that you have made the decision to experience an initiation ceremony, you must prepare to leave everything behind, resolve loose ends, give up old habits, and make it good with your relationships. This severance preparation is a clear opportunity to "practice your own dying." Indeed, some bright day you *will* leave it all behind, and cross the threshold into the sacred passage. This knowing in the gut, that someday you will die, will guide your preparations.

For some, this is not just a personal healing but a return to the wisdom of the ancestors, a re-amination of ways that have been lost or stolen, a reclaiming of ways that existed in balance with nature before civilization and foreign ideologies were enforced upon us.

All ceremonies of passage involve some sort of hardship, risk, or trial. You must prepare yourself, physically, emotionally, mentally, and spiritually, to survive a period of three or four days and nights of solitude in the "wilderness," with no convenience other than the contents of your backpack. Even if you are an avid explorer or backpacker you will probably feel the same apprehension the seasoned sailor feels before a long voyage. After all, Nature is unpredictable -- and her power is beyond imagining. You will go to her and place yourself in her hands. By preparing to surrender to and endure whatever she has to teach you, you are probably confronting some basic fears. Remember that fear itself can be a teacher of clarity of purpose and wisdom of heart. The pumping of adrenalin becomes a feeling. Feeling becomes thought; thought becomes enlightened action. The body knows fear, just as it knows the wind, the darkness, and the silence. This is where transformation occurs. The sacred teachings and inner knowledge of your ancestors will come out to meet you on your path and you will be shaped by the earth herself.

You will be asked to participate in a series of preparatory meetings (council) where you will meet with a small group of others. Prepare carefully and well. These councils are a forum for deep listening and open sharing. All voices are equal. Your guides are midwives who will help you give birth to new perceptions. You may not hold to the same value or belief system; nevertheless, they seek your safety, well-being, and self-educational growth. They cannot and will not take the steps of preparation for you or accompany

you across the threshold.

You and those with whom you meet comprise a community. This community has been formed to insure the survival of every one of its members. Therefore, you will probably feel close to the others, especially as the threshold phase draws near. You will become vividly aware of their emotions, feelings, and thoughts, even as you are of your own. Hopefully, you will find yourself willing to share your tenderest places with everyone, and they with you.

The survival of any community depends on the mutual trust of its members. This community is a microcosm of the human world, and is a way of seeing your place in it.

Are you extroverted, introverted, bold or shy? No matter, you will take part in the essential act of mutual survival. You will confirm your oneness with your kind by laying your body and soul on the line. And so our role within the human community is no different than that of the chipmunk. Though separate beings, we exist for the well being of the collective.

Look to the back of this manual for an equipment list as well as descriptions and recommendations pertaining to other animals and natural phenomena you may encounter.



THE DAY WALK

The day walk is a journey upon the face of the earth, a ceremony of preparation, a pilgrimage through the mirror of nature. In the natural world, signs and symbols of your inward journey are reflected. The walk is a distilled version of the threshold phase of the vision fast.

During your walk, certain spirits or powers of nature, which typify the nature of your own qualities, are attracted by and reveal themselves to you. With your help, they weave an allegorical or symbolic story which indicates future direction, your inherent gifts, and the kinds of ceremonies that you might perform during the vision fast.

The walk is customarily taken one month before the actual initiation (threshold) time commences. You prepare the night before by packing an emergency kit and a few other items you might need for a day's journey. These should include adequate water and a cell phone or other communication device to be used only in the event of an emergency. Inform someone of the location and duration of your walk.

Get a good night's rest. An important dream may arise on this night.

You walk for several hours, or the entire day if desired, in a safe, natural place. It is suggested that no food is taken on this day -- until after the sun has set (ultimately, the decision is yours). Set forth on a wandering, intuitive course, without consciously attempting to reach any goal. As you wander, keep your eyes open. Be aware if you are feeling "drawn" in any direction or to anything. Listen to and sense the consciousness of all that is around you.

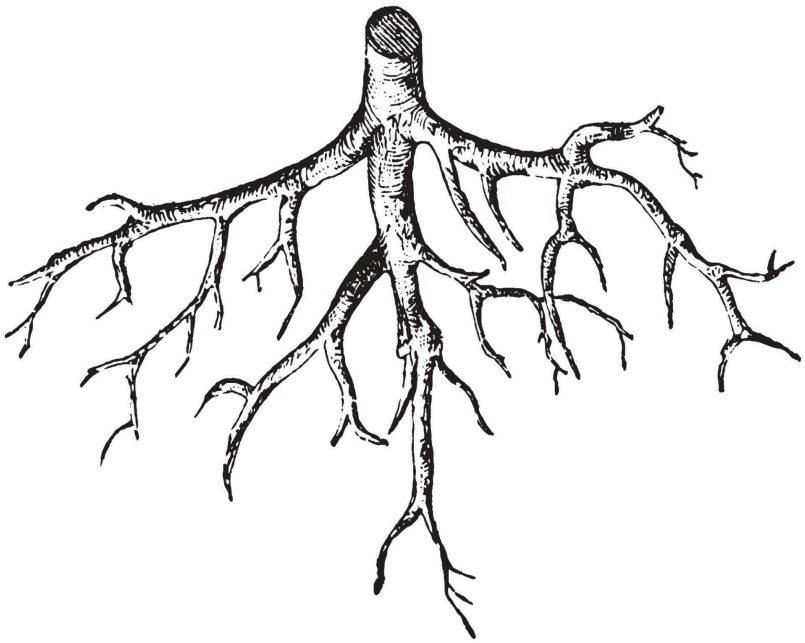
Remember to honor those who lived on the land long before you and to accept their presence, wisdom, and enduring connection to the earth. In this way you are not only reconnecting with yourself but with the Indigenous people who have always understood that the land is full of stories waiting to be heard.

The beginning and the end of your day walk are marked by ceremony. The ceremony that you perform at these points may be elaborate or simple, but it must involve your focused attention and your gratitude to the land for her teaching and safe-keeping.

It is wise to keep a journal account of your walk and to be familiar with its basic plot -- for it is a kind of "life story" and you have the leading role. Like your life, this story has a beginning and an end. Be prepared to share this adventure with your guides, or a close friend. They may be able to point out salient features of the story you may have overlooked or forgotten.

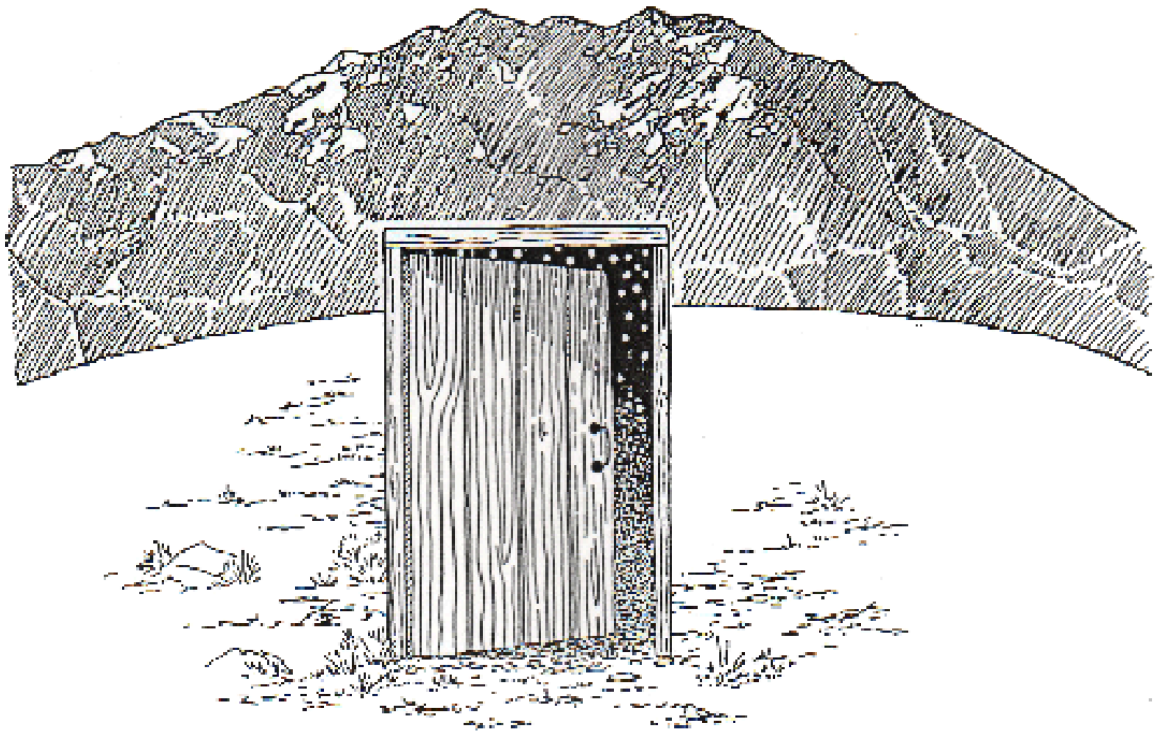
Like longer solo time in nature, the day walk is an exercise of balance and attunement. It is not a challenge of the elements or heights, nor is it an endurance contest. The walker maintains connection with the beauty of life and the reality of death as both are reflected by the world of nature.

Pay special attention to loved ones and friends who call strongly to you as you walk. Some of these individuals may have already died. They can act as your teachers, heroes, and helpers, watching as you grow and help to strengthen the circle of your purpose.



STAGE TWO:

THE SACRED MOUNTAINS OF THE THRESHOLD



THE THRESHOLD

When you step across the threshold, you enter what some might call a “sacred” space. In other words, it is a place worthy of respect. There is no other human here to define your sense of what is real for you. The apparent, physical body of the land is all around you. You may sense your own insignificance. You may surrender to the presence of Nature, acknowledging that you exist within it.

The word threshold is derived from the AngloSaxon *thrashold* (or "threshing hold"); you will be threshed, like wheat. The chaff will be snatched away by the hungry wind. The seeds will fall to earth, where they will become food for your people. For three or four days and nights you will be held there, in the eye of the threshing-storm of memory. You will face whatever nature brings you. You will become one with that which thrashes you.

Of course the concept of the threshold space comes from a far older wisdom and should be acknowledged as such. In the Nahuatl native tongue, the Mictlan, or underworld, is the place where transformation begins, where you will be broken open and renewed. The rays of Tonatiuh (the Sun) will sweep over you, removing the chaff that is no longer needed and leaving the seeds that will feed the people.

The Mictlan teaches you to shed the old and embrace the new. When you step across its threshold you are no longer who you were, but part of the great cycle of life and death, the eternal Quiahuitl (rain) that nourishes all life.

Some have returned from their threshold time lamenting that they did not have a "vision." When we asked them what they meant, they invariably imagined "vision" as an event of great magnitude and power, an intense moment of non-ordinary reality filled with angels, grails, or rapturous light. But this is only one of many kinds of vision.

Vision is wisdom. Vision is insight into the nature of things. Vision is feeling in balance and harmony with all creation. Vision is the ability to see the future. Vision is the ability to dream.

Above all, vision is merely opening the eyes to see what already is.

Those who cross the threshold are never betrayed by vision. Sometimes, however, they are betrayed by their own limited definitions. Take care that you do not enter with your eyes closed!

The crossing of the threshold is a personal yet formal statement, a self-definition, a step in an ancient ceremony. You do not cross the threshold empty-handed. You carry with you the inherent wisdom of your ancestors, and the tools or components that were available to them from ancient times. Twelve of these components are offered below. Study them. Use them as you choose. Combine or change them to suit your own needs. Consult with your own teachers
and guides.



1. FINDING YOUR PLACE ON THE EARTH

You will usually have one day to focus on finding a place to live during the threshold time. This is often the day before you go out alone. You will have a companion, a buddy, who will be your unseen partner during the days and nights of solitude. Your buddy will be close enough to help you if you are in trouble and you will offer the same support in return. The two of you will find separate places of power situated within a half-mile of each other. This arrangement is sometimes a little difficult and requires friendly, responsible coordination between the two of you.

Truly, the place of power which you seek is inside you. As you enter into the wilderness to look for your retreat, remember that you seek a place where the inner and outer worlds become one. The assent of your whole being is the sign you are looking for. This abode of power, where you will stand, sit, and lay your body down, can be almost anywhere, as long as *you* are there, empowering it with your spirit. In turn, the beings of your dwelling will bless and nourish you and give you, not what you want, but what you need. This place you seek, then, will validate and respond to your own personal power.

Watch yourself search for and then discover your place. There is much in your behavior to observe. How do you set about looking? Do you have an image of the place in mind? Are you easily satisfied or are you very particular about what your place looks like, or where it is situated? Do you keep personal safety uppermost in your mind, or not? Do you plan to hole up like a turtle or range on the exposed ridges like a bighorn sheep? Do you resent being within walking distance of your buddy or do you welcome the idea

of having him/her/them as a neighbor? **There is no right or wrong way - only your way and your responsibility to return safely to your community.**

When you find your dwelling, spend some time there. Lie down on the ground and relax against its feel. Will your soul find strength and insight here? If you were a warrior, would you choose this place to make your last stand? Is this a good place to "die?" When you return to civilization, you will carry a strong image of this place in your heart. It will symbolize your own personal power. Do not let yourself be ruled by the fear that you have made the wrong choice -- unless, in your heart, you are convinced you must look further.

There are many different kinds of good places. Some are high and exposed; some are low and protected. Usually, there is something distinctive about them, certain features that resonate with the soul: a cliff, a boulder face, a special tree, the hollow of a ridge, a strangely cleared area, a spring, a cave, or a terrace in a canyon.

Certain survival considerations must also be a part of your search. Will you be overexposed to the elements? What would you do in the event of high winds, snow, rain, or a heavy thunderstorm? Is your place accessible only to a mountain goat? Once you are up there, can you get back down easily? Responsibility to yourself begins with your ability to take care of yourself and not be an unnecessary risk to your community.

2. FOOD

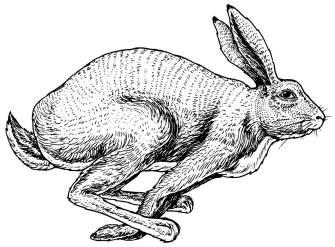
Traditionally, solo time is also a time to abstain from food. However, this is a personal choice and one we cannot make for you.

With no meals to organize your day around, you are going without modern life's most common security blanket. Fasting will teach you a great deal about your psychological need for structure. You will find out how much of your physical hunger is really just social programming. Entering a space devoid of any pre-programmed patterns is a powerful tool for self discovery.

Fasting is a practical, time-honored means of attaining clarity. The empty, quivering sensations at the pit of your stomach are more than hunger. You are experiencing emptiness of self. You are letting go of the toxins and poisons of your spiritual (and physical) food. Since the dawn of human history, our ancestors have forged this bond between physical, psychological, mental, and spiritual purification.

Again, whether you fast, and to what degree, is entirely up to you. For some this is an essential part of their solo time and wouldn't have it any other way. For others, the fasting itself is too much of a distraction, or poses too many health questions to be practicable. If you have a history of disordered eating, we suggest you bring food and nourish yourself.

Should you have further concerns regarding your ability to fast for three or four days and nights (because of your particular physical or psychological makeup), be sure to consult with your physician and your guides in advance.



3. WALKING LIGHTLY ON THE EARTH

Like any other animal, we belong to the earth. And like any other animal, we leave signs of our passing. Unfortunately, we modern folks tend to leave considerably more signs than our ancestors did. Many of us have forgotten how to walk lightly in a wilderness place. An alarming amount of trash is piling up in our national parks, forests, wildernesses and highest peaks. Items, artifacts, and sacred sites of both historical and current Indigenous groups are being vandalized and stolen. Campfires are eating up dead vegetation and ground cover. Growing things are being hacked, trimmed, notched, carved, and otherwise mutilated. Species great and small are hunted, killed and tortured, not from need, but from thoughtlessness or for sport.

During your solo time you are doubly responsible for the way in which you interact with your environment. You are responsible because you are an informed, intelligent human being who would rather cooperate with than conquer nature.

During the time you are here, you are being asked to walk lightly, to be aware of where you set your feet, to preserve and nurture the life around you in all its myriad forms.

For three or four days and nights you will be uncommonly aware of the interface between you and nature. You will see for yourself how human and nature rub off on each other. Your joints and muscles

will feel it. The earth too will feel the impress of your body. She will feel the change if you alter the landscape. She will feel an abandoned cigarette filter, plastic water bottle, or shred of nylon, for a long time. She will be quite aware of any unthinking havoc you wreak within the infinitely delicate biosystem which is your home. We can be aware because Nature is aware. We would not be aware if we were not of her.

Yes, you belong here, like the fox, the turtle, the cactus, and the wren. And yes you are a guest here. Every natural thing around you is saying welcome, making allowances for your presence, accommodating you. This is all the more reason to express your gratitude, to honor your hosts. If you have the freedom to move about, then you also have the freedom to be still. Whether moving or stationary, remember that you are generating spoor so that the spirits of the wilderness can track you. Don't make it easy for them. They enjoy subtlety. After a couple of good rains, all signs should be gone. Only your spirit will remain.

4. TALKING WITH THE WIND

Too many of us have been taught from an early age to denigrate or ignore our inner voice, the voice through which plants and animals speak to us. We have been led to doubt what we cannot directly sense or prove with our measuring sticks. We have "learned" to devalue the inner coherency of our own self-perception of truth and meaning, preferring to put our trust in what we mistakenly believe to be the "evidence" of our materialistic senses. If our inner voice speaks, we are skeptical of its motives and origin, seeing as how the voice apparently is attached to our mortal selves. We have "learned" to underestimate the capacity of our minds and bodies to perceive, create and know.

The exercise of intuitive cognition -- one of humankind's greatest gifts -- begins with the exercise of respecting and listening to your inner voice. If you cannot value your own inherent wisdom the Hawk, screaming above your head, has no words for you, and Sage, upon which you pillow your dreaming head, has nothing to reveal.

Some of us have been conditioned to disregard our inner voice - the sacred channel through which the land, the plants, and the animals speak to us. For example, colonization diminished the ways our ancestors connected with the natural world. Many of us have been encouraged to abandon the great wisdom that is inside, to question the ancient knowledge that passes through our bodies, hearts, and

spirits. When we remember the sacred knowledge of our inner voice we begin to heal the wounds of colonization and remember the ways of our ancestors - ways that may help us toward a better, balanced, and whole future.



5. DREAMING

Traditionally, dreams of the threshold period were considered to be sacred and of great life import. Not only is the initiate dreaming, but they are *being dreamed* by the sacred ancestors.

Sometimes dreams are wiser than waking. - Black Elk

But when I breathe with the birds,
The spirit of wrath becomes the spirit of blessing,
And the dead begin from their dark to sing in my sleep.
- Theodore Roethke, “Journey to the Interior”

All dreams contain wisdom by which we grow and change. The dreams of this ceremony contain transformational power. Sometimes their message is unmistakably clear. They transmit a definite sign. Other dreams seem less obvious, more complicated, with shifting, changing episodes and vague symbols. Yet they cling heavily to the waking consciousness. It is probably better to let such dreams "do their work" in the alembic of feeling, without attempting to rationally analyze them.

Other dreams are profane or riddled with the anxieties of “regular” life. These dreams are also of use, for they provide continuity and a sense of proportion to the perceptions of the dreamer. All forms of dreaming, including fantasies, daydreams, and wool gatherings, compose a tapestry into which are woven the currents, plots, symbols, and colors of your picture of yourself. In other words, your dreams on this journey are maps to the sacred mountains of your life.

One way to read a dream map is to "own" every detail of the dream. For example: "And then the elder (of me) went down to the river (of me) but could not find the sailor (of me). A child (of me) was playing beside the rushing water (of me) and fell in. The elder (of me) tore a root from the tree (of me) and

threw it to the child (of me) to hang on to, etc." By claiming each element of the dream, you are able to see more clearly which roles the different parts of you are playing in the dream-drama.

Daydreams may arise in which you are the "star" or leading character, or you play a superhuman or uncharacteristic role as a savior or warrior. Do not belittle such dreaming. It may be the dream-wind of your sacred ancestors stirring your mind. If a particular dream of heroism returns unbidden, again and again, then you can begin to see a trail that leads into the realities of your life. If the trail is of benefit to your people and to the land, it is a trail worth walking.

In many Native and Indigenous cultures, dreams are powerful connections with the spirit world, ancestors, and the deeper wisdom of the earth. In traditions like those of the Lakota, Navajo, and many others, dreams are seen as a bridge to the unseen, a way to receive wisdom from the spirit world, ancestors, and even animals and plants. They are not seen as mere fragments of the mind, but as messages with the power to shape the journey of an individual and a community. In the Lakota tradition, the concept of wakȟáŋ (sacredness) is deeply woven into the fabric of dreaming. Dreams are sacred instructions from the spiritual realm and are perceived by the the wičháša wakáŋ (holy person) or medicine person, who interprets them as messages of guidance for life.

In such traditions, dreams are very carefully handed down, for they are messages not for one individual but for the entire community or even the earth itself.

5. THE DEATH LODGE

Preparing to die physically and preparing for a symbolic death are remarkably similar in the natural process of how “to die in order to step into the new world.” In hospice, likely from the Hawaiian Ho’oponono practice of reconciliation and forgiveness, there is a saying written by people who have sat with dying people: there are 5 things that need to be said in order to complete a relationship - I forgive you, I am so sorry for the ways I have hurt you, thank you, I love you, and goodbye. In a symbolic dying the last step might be “let’s try again with the new information we’ve learned about each other”, or “I forgive you but I can’t trust you so I need to say goodbye as I step into this new phase of my life.”

This can be called cleaning up our social karma. And some of this can be done in what we call The Death Lodge. Here, as best we can, we entertain people who we call in to have a conversation with, or people who show up unexpectedly. What do we, and they, have to say to each other? This is a time to express

as honestly as we can what we need to say to them (love, gratitude, anger, regret, etc.) in order to "make it good" with them if possible. Or to begin this process.

The hardest work is the expression of forgiveness and apology, which involves honest conversations with the person who has hurt us, or who we have hurt. Here we must honestly and deeply listen to what they have to say to us as well, without putting words in their mouths.

Some people find it meaningful and supportive to build or find an actual place on the land to do this work. Some use stones, sticks, pinecones, etc. to build it. Others might do it through the day as a walking meditation. This is up to what works for you and what is meaningful. Be sure to close the lodge down when you are done so that you are not bombarded by more people wanting to come into the lodge. If you like you can reopen it once you have rested … or not. The Death Lodge is a ceremony that can be done again and again in our lives to stay "current" with our people.

6. THE PURPOSE CIRCLE

This circle of which the wind speaks is the most ancient and reverend of ceremonial symbols. It is important that you acquire an understanding of the meaning and use of the "Purpose Circle," or "Circle of the Self."

The simple, yet sophisticated circle-symbol has been variously utilized by the Australian Aboriginal people (the Sacred Enclosure), Native Americans (the Medicine Wheel, the Sweatlodge, the Sun Dance, the Kiva, etc.), the Mayan/Aztec (the Calendar), the Tibetan Buddhists (the Mandala), the Celts (the Wheel of the Year), the Jewish people (the Wheel of Life), and many others.

Ordinarily, the Purpose Circle (Circle of Self) is aligned to the four directions, or powers, as seen in the four points of the compass. These four directions represent the four seasons, the four developmental ages, the four quadrants of the heavens, the four dimensions, etc. The four-directioned circle of purpose, like the tabernacle, the cross, the sweat lodge, the mandala, etc., is a whole, balanced, symbolic representation of the psyche, or self, in a regenerative relationship with the cosmos.

Within this ceremony the Purpose Circle "comes to life" when the initiate builds such a circle with the intention of being its inhabitant.

When you enter your circle, you symbolically take responsibility for your connection in the greater web of life. You acknowledge the ancient truth: "I am what I perceive, and I am what perceives me".

The circle is built sometime prior to the last night of the threshold period in an area selected with great care. It is best to lay down the cardinal stones first, aligning the north and south stones to the North Star. Then the east and west stones can be added. When this basic framework is down, the circle of stones may be elaborated as you are prompted. The circle need be no more than six feet across and can be composed of any material symbols you see fit to add to the basic stones. Make the building of your Purpose Circle a labor of love. Your circle will enclose, protect, and awaken you. It will follow you through the wilderness of your life.

Completed, the circle becomes a nexus of your power place, a magnet of spiritual attraction. You cannot ignore it anymore than you can ignore yourself. By sunset of the last day, you might want to formally enter the Purpose Circle and begin your vigil, staying awake through the long night, crying for a vision. Or you might not.

There are many ceremonial ways to utilize the power and meaning of the Purpose Circle. Your guides will be happy to consult with you regarding the many ways in which the circle can be used as an effective ceremonial tool.

When you leave your place you will symbolically carry your Purpose Circle with you. It will surround and protect you as you go. Having oriented yourself to the universe in the ancient, sacred manner of your ancestors, you will never quite be able to divest yourself of your circle-burden of responsibility and power. As you must erase all other signs of your sojourn in the sacred world of the threshold, you must do the same with your Purpose Circle, at most leaving a center stone, knowing that it will remain there for a long time to come.

It is crucial to remember the privilege inherent in being part of these ceremonies, especially when considering the long history of colonization and forced separation from ancestral practices. Many Indigenous peoples have been removed from practicing these ceremonies in their original, unbroken forms due to the violence of colonization. For anyone joining a rite of passage ceremony today, it should be approached with reverence that comes from an understanding of this history.

7. ASKING FOR A VISION

We do not go to the sacred mountain merely for ourselves. If we bring nothing back for the welfare of our people, then we have no reason to go.

Alone in the darkness, ringed by the circle of your purpose, you can ask/cry/pray/wish for a vision. This act has no specified form or content. The only stipulation is that it comes from the heart.

There is no human but yourself to hear you. Songs, chants, dances, incoherent sounds, even tears and silence are equally as powerful. The god, spirit, human, animal, or power you address is both outside and inside your circle. Indeed, your circle has no sides. The four directions, plus the other two (skyward and earthward), which shape your circle into a sphere or gyroscope (with your spirit providing inertial guidance), are symbolic inlets and outlets through which power and influence flow unimpeded.

It is not necessary to receive immediate answers. The answers will best be characterized by your actions when you return to the world you left behind. Perhaps, for a time, silence is the best answer.

Many have reported that the long, dark vigil of the Purpose Circle took on profound meaning when they imagined that they had reached the last night of their life. Like seeds broken from the mother stem, they had been carried by the winds of regeneration to this place. The husk of their spirit was about to fall away. Soon they would emerge into the dawn of death. They sang their death song and called on the spirits of their friends, loved ones, ancestors, teachers, and wisdom guides to gather around and witness their emergence from the underworld.

In Lakota tradition, the act of seeking a vision is known as haŋbléčheyapi, which translates to "crying for a vision." This practice is not just an individual endeavor, but one deeply rooted in the connection to the larger web of life, a process through which one seeks to align their personal journey with the wisdom and teachings of the ancestors, the spirit world, and the natural forces around them.

During the haŋbléčheyapi, the seeker is open to receiving visions in various forms including that of an animal spirit, representing the qualities or lessons the seeker must embrace or understand.

To partake in this ceremony is to reawaken the ancient wisdom that has sustained generations, and to honor the resilience of those who have preserved these teachings despite countless challenges.

8. EMERGENCE (GIVING BIRTH TO YOURSELF)

As the first light of dawn touches your eyes, birthing is quickened. Soon your questing spirit will re-cross the threshold and be enveloped by the body of the "profane" world. Symbolically, you will emerge as newly born. But this time you will not be innocent, naked, or helpless. You are confirming that you have been born into a greater self.

Pause a while in your circle and thank the spirits for keeping you. Stand erect on your two feet, proud and tall in the dawn-time of long shadows.

Before you leave your circle, remember to ask yourself a very important question: "For what purpose am I returning?" You may not receive a solid answer. Nevertheless, you are formally acknowledging -- one last time -- your reasons for embarking on this journey.

Trust your emotions and feelings. If you did not gain the insight or illumination you had hoped for, remember that the seed is growing within. You will be reaping the fruits of your experience for a long time to come.

Erase all signs of your stay. If you tarry too long you may be overwhelmed by a wistful feeling that it would really be much easier to remain than to face what awaits you in your life. As the early Christian saint St. George breaks free of his blankets at the dawn call of the dragon, break free from your place of power. The act of shouldering your pack represents your willing assumption of the responsibilities and privileges of your new life station. The others will also be returning. Your teachers and guides will be waiting for you at basecamp. They will see the circle of your purpose dancing in your eyes.

STAGE THREE:

INCORPORATION (THE RETURN)



INCORPORATION (THE RETURN)

As you turn your back on your power place and walk to meet your buddy, your excitement is probably mixed with apprehension. What are you returning to? What monsters lie ahead? It is important to remember that you will successfully "incorporate" to the extent that you are able into the world.

Without a doubt, you have reason to fear. The world to which you return is far more malicious and defeating than the solitude and hunger of the threshold time. In the world you must love and work and be responsible. You must somehow survive the routines, the pressures, the crises, the relationships, and all the future trials and tribulations of your new life station. You must nurture the flame of your purpose and carry its warmth to the darkest corners. Above all, you must teach yourself to see that the world is not only profane, but equally as sacred, equally as worthy of your quest.

Now that your eyes are opened, you know how great the challenge is. This last step of the ceremony is the most difficult of all to take. Everything that has gone before was mere preparation. The lessons you gained from your recent experience must be practically applied. You wonder: "Will I be able to hold onto my resolve and not lose the vision?" Indeed, that is the crux of the issue.

Rebirth into the gross, secular body of the modern world is almost always accompanied by contractions. Painful confusion caused by these contractions can be mitigated by personal preparedness and ceremonial attention to the rhythms of incorporation. If certain steps are taken, the confusion and difficulty is eased. The following steps are critical to the return. During these moments, simple ceremonies may be performed effectively.

MEETING YOUR BUDDY. The first person you see will probably be your buddy. The two of you can meet at the stonepile and dismantle it before heading back to basecamp. This meeting can be awkward. You have not used your voice to communicate with another human being since you entered the threshold time. Give each other space to express whatever needs to be expressed, whether it be hugs, tears, silence, or just plain bashfulness.

MEETING THE GROUP. Your guides did not follow you across the threshold. Though they waited for you at a distance and sought your safety and well-being, they have gone about their own business. Now you must come into the body of their company and again be one of a group. At this point the basecamp people may want to formally welcome you back.

THE GIVEAWAY. The next event in your return is a symbolic enactment of your willingness to share your vision, whatever you feel it might have been. Some people bring back tiny stones, twisted pieces of wood or things they have made, to give away to others. Some bring back power songs, dances or poems. Try to enact a personal ceremony of giving, for it is dangerous to receive illumination without channeling it to others. You may feel neither powerful nor holy. You may feel completely bushed. It is the *willingness* to be a channel, to give away, that matters.

EATING (COMMUNION). While you were alone, you may not have had anything to eat. Now that you are together with others, it is time to eat. It is fitting that those who have journeyed together should share a simple meal while emotions run high. Some feel little hunger. Others are ravenous. It is good to eat at least a little, to share with others the fruit of the earth and to acknowledge the beauty of your own mortality.

FAREWELL TO THE SACRED MOUNTAINS. The time comes to consciously turn your back on the sacred mountains, to let go of them, knowing that they will always be waiting there. It might help to tell yourself that you will never see them again. Then they will haunt you with their regenerative power. Thank the spirits who dwell there and ask for their continued help. It is important to then turn toward the life and people who wait for you, and say a full “Yes” to the return.

WASHING AWAY THE DUST OF THE SACRED WORLD. By symbolically washing hands, feet, hair, or entire body, you can effectively signify your resolution to return, and not to linger at the threshold. This ceremony is enhanced by the changing of clothes.

ENTERING A MOTOR VEHICLE. An automobile is not only a small, enclosed, necessarily social space, but is a dangerous machine. It is one of the deadlier symbols of modern civilization. Be aware (on a deliberately conscious level) that you are entering it, trusting it, submitting to its environment, and/or driving it. Once you enter it, there is no turning back. You are committed to the dangerous road home, to the return. Drivers must pay special attention to the "vehicle threshold." Driving takes a completely different set of perceptions and reactions. You must pay attention to the matters of driving safely.

ENTERING BUILDINGS, ENCOUNTERING STRANGERS, BUYING THINGS. One fact becomes quite apparent on the journey home. No one else in the world at large seems to know or care about what you have just done. Everyone is scurrying about, intent on their own quest. All the symbols of civilization come rushing back: advertising, places to dine or sleep, drugstores, bars, freeways, subdivisions, thousands upon thousands of cars, lights and sounds.

How easy it is to overload, to eat too much, to want too much (because everything is offered), to obey the call of old addictions, to buy what is not needed, etc. A balanced person is wary of the plentitude but is not overcome by remorse if they make a "mistake." You must not fall into the trap of feeling disgust at everything worldly. Loved ones, friends, and family live in this world.

HOME. The threshold of your home represents another important landmark in incorporation. Try to give yourself at least 24 hours to incorporate the experience you have just been through before you take on the world outside your own den. This time of reflection will help to center you for the task that lies ahead.

At this time it is good to go back to the night of your Purpose Circle, to put yourself at the center of the "Universe Wheel" again. This is not an act of nostalgia, but a symbolic exercise which enables you to walk with balance and precision through stormy times to come. Practice envisioning your Purpose Circle around you. With disciplined effort, the circle will become a tool. With it you will be able to tap sources of strength, courage and power within yourself.

Members of your family and close friends may or may not be interested in your experience. Their life has continued while you were gone. Though they undoubtedly care, loved ones may have other concerns. Those who are interested may exhibit a distressing tendency to be curious to see if any changes have occurred in you. Those who are ready to hear your experiences will not be cynical or mocking. Their

questions may help you discover other dimensions to your story. Beware of talking about it too much or to the wrong people. Rather than to bolster your ego, talking will drain you of vital energy. If you find this

happening, stop. Hold it close as a secret knowing.

THE COUNCIL. A council may be convened within a day of your return from the threshold. If so, you will be asked to tell your story to your “guides”.

The "guides" are graduates of the threshold. Their purpose is to listen to the stories, one by one, and to reflect back ("mirror") the meaning of the story to the teller in such a way as to empower them to accept and live the story.

In other words, the guides are birth attendants, midwives, helping the tellers to give birth to their stories. Only then can the story grow and become the basis for the health and well-being of communities and bioregions.

The guides know that your story is the foundation on which a life may build itself. They also know that all stories share a "mono-plot," an archetype of initiation. On the simplest level, the story is about a human passing into adulthood. It doesn't matter how old you are, the process of initiation remains the same.

The story is about how you earned your story. It is a microcosm of your life and contains the ingredients of your personal "medicine." Because your experience occurred within the natural order, the story is interlayered with the physical, psychological, mental, and spiritual dimensions of nature. At certain points in the narrative, the human and the natural become interlinked. These interlinking moments are an important source of the "medicine."

How do you tell your story? There are many ways. A chronological account of events may not suit your purpose. Remember that your story has an inward dimension and an outward one. Even while you were doing this or that, you were feeling, thinking, remembering, talking, praying. What happened inside is every bit as important as what happened outside. Another suggestion might be to tell your story as if it were a dream. Now that it is over, it may very well seem like one. Scan your dream for important symbols or significant events. Talk about those. Whatever you do, don't belittle your own story as being

inconsequential or uninteresting. An attitude like that may defeat you from the start. **Honor yourself for what you have done. Hold your head high. You are one of those who have been initiated.**

The "mirror" of the elders is a means of answering such questions as “What is this person’s ‘way’ of walking through life? How do they get through hard times? What do they do when they are lonely, scared, bored, delighted? What are the qualities they show? What are their hopes, dreams, yearnings,

fears?" Sometimes the elders see themes, patterns, potentialities that are not immediately apparent in the fabric of the story. Their life experience gives them the right to look ahead, and to respond soul to soul. Their mirror is almost always "positive" as opposed to negative, for they know that their validation is the stuff of health and vitality.

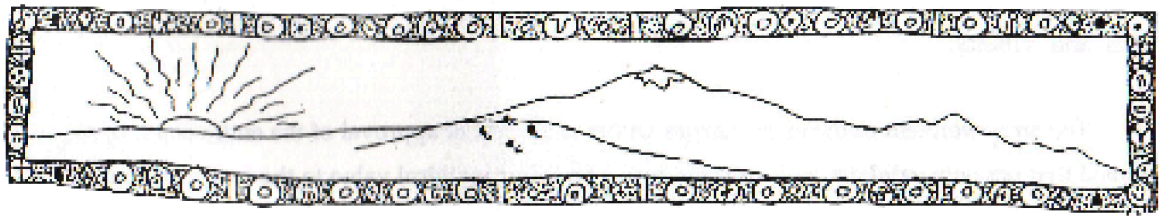
The empowerment of the elders carries within it the seal of approval of the entire community, approval that not only validates and confirms, but defines our mythical value to the earth and our fellow humans. Obviously, we don't have much of that kind of empowerment today - or those kinds of elders. Because we lack meaningful passage rites into mature (and maturer) stages of life, there are few adults capable of recognizing and honoring those who, by dint of self-initiation, attain levels of maturity that benefit the community.

REVISITING YOUR PLACE OF POWER. A year after your return, you must find the opportunity to go back to your place of power. **Remember, the place of power is inside as well as out.** Perhaps most appropriate is to find this place close to your own community. This is the last formal step of incorporation. With this visit, your ceremony "officially" ends.

This return to your power place is undertaken on your own initiative and is not a group activity or party, you go alone to this place, performing whatever ceremony seems appropriate to your life at that time, renewing the seeds of commitment to the understandings you have been given.

This last step can be difficult. No matter how you get there, or with whom, you must go *alone* to your power place, make certain, as you did before, that you have left no evidence of your stay there -with the possible exception of a stone at the center of your place.

Remember to tell someone where you are going!



Vision without execution is a hallucination. - Thomas Edison

Usually, within a few weeks, the flush of excitement that is a by-product of your ceremony has worn off. By now you have had plenty of opportunities to "test" yourself against the monsters of your life. Perhaps you have begun to fear falling back into old habits of being and doing. No one can stay "high" forever. And what a dull world it would be if they did. Nor can you expect a free ride. As you learned from your experience, intent and commitment to it, are what got you through those long days and nights of the threshold. An easy, blissed-out path is not the answer to the riddle of your existence. As Narcissus put it: "There is only the peace that must be won again and again, each new day of our lives" *(*Herman Hesse, *Narcissus and Goldmund).*

Those who have returned from the sacred mountain need not be surprised by a common and often necessary depression. Nevertheless, when the initiate hits bottom, they may have difficulty seeing anything else but the bottom.

Wisdom literature tells us that humans experience life in rhythms of high and low, that the ascent of the mountain is followed by a descent. We are reminded that ups and downs are interdependent and necessary for the growth of the self.

Every spiritual tradition teaches the inevitability, even the *necessity,* of the darkness that follows illumination. The yogi teaches his disciples to return to the ordinary when he says, "After *samadhi,* we

sweep the floor." You can go around with your head in the clouds, but that does not keep the dust from seeping through the cracks. Dreams and visions will not sweep your floor, but your vision may bring you many dirty floors to sweep.

Many there are who have visions. Few there are who make their visions real. The key to vision is *action* -- the "doing of the vision." The most difficult step you must take is to bring illumination back from the rising sun and take it down into the murky, labyrinthine caverns of doing.

A good measure of the vision of a human is time. "Flash in the pans" come and go. They expend their energy in one great burst and then they burn out. Likewise, others disintegrate in remorse and self-disgust because they keep falling short of an impossible or unrealistic vision.

The trail ahead can be walked at your own speed. Everything does not have to be "figured out." Your ability to persevere is what counts -- your refusal to be victimized by yourself or circumstance.

When you were alone in the ceremony, you gained access to an inexhaustible well of solace and inspiration. This connection will never be broken. Someday you will go back to your Mother Earth and give your body to her. That is why you can always go to her and ask for strength, wisdom, and understanding. She will never reject you. Never will a visit to her pass without a lesson or an answered question.

Swept along in the flow of ordinary life, it is surprisingly easy to let events of the moment obscure the gift of your experience. Pressures of work, relationship, and routine, often seem to hinder an honest heart from returning to the regenerative presence of the land. The most often heard complaint is: "I've been too busy to get away."

One of the most effective ways to deal with a busy schedule is to make sure the schedule includes periodic returns to the natural world. Once you have placed these visits on your calendar of future events, you will begin to look forward to the healing times you spend with nature.

PLANNING YOUR OWN CEREMONY

Plan to utilize ceremonies that are relevant to your own life situation and the questions of your existence. Without the value system of the participant, this ceremony is merely an empty form. You will flesh the ancient skeleton with the stuff of your own life passage. Though your guides and others can be of help to you as you plan your own ceremonies, the actual creation and performance of them will be up to you -- and your sacred ancestors.

During severance, threshold, and incorporation, you will perform your own ceremonies, use your own symbols, pray your own prayers, sing your own songs. You are under no constraint to be anyone other than who you are. This is especially important during threshold time where you are entirely alone on the land.

The study of your own ceremonial process begins with the following questions. Your answers to these questions will help you to understand your own unique orientation to the creation and use of ceremony.

If you consider yourself to be a non-ceremonial person, read on anyway. It may be you will discover that you have unknowingly performed a lot of ceremonies during your lifetime. Remember, it is important to formally mark only what you are ready to mark. Don't force a ceremony that you are not prepared to enact the results of.



QUESTIONS TO HELP YOU DEVELOP YOUR OWN CEREMONIES

1. What am I marking (formalizing, celebrating, ritualizing)?

2. Where would my ceremony fit within the three stages of the rite of passage?

    - *Severance* (separation, termination, parting, letting go, conclusion)?
    - *Threshold* (transition, change, adjustment, shift in role, status, or task, period of extended depression, transformation, renewal)?
    - *Incorporation* (return, joining, union, reestablishment of harmony, new responsibilities, new beginnings)?

3. What symbolic actions would best express my intentions to mark this severance, threshold, or incorporation ceremony? Circle possibilities or write down your own.

    Examples: burying, burning, smashing, changing name, bathing, crossing thresholds, masks, vows, cutting flesh or hair, heaping stones, aligning stones, chanting, singing, being silent, changing clothes, use of candles or fire, nakedness, dancing, exchanging gifts, self-purification, tying or untying knots, sprinkling or elixir, playing an instrument, praying, etc.

4. What symbols, human or natural, do I want to use as part of the ceremony? As you will be traveling light, you cannot take along everything that is meaningful to you. What symbols would you want to have with you on the day of your death? *These* symbols will lend power and meaning to your ceremony.

5. As you become familiar with the components, symbols and actions of your ceremony, you must also ask yourself if you intend to speak to anyone or anything. If so, what do you want to say, and to whom?

6. Knowing what you want to say, you can arrange the events of your ceremony in order, making certain that the ceremony has an *ending, middle,* and *beginning,* as all things do.

   Beginning:

   Middle:

   End:

7. When you have planned your ceremony, you can then decide whether or not you want to have witnesses ("in spirit" or in flesh). In the vision fast rite of passage, only the threshold phase excludes the physical presence of other humans.

   If so, who/what?

8. Finally, your ceremony must be located in natural space and time. Ask yourself where you want to do this ceremony and when.

Notes:

PREPARATION

LIVING IN BALANCE WITH THE LAND

The wilderness is not a dangerous place. It is a "wild" place only in the sense that there are no civilized comforts there. You will probably be safer in the "wild" than in the crowded city. Though the wilderness has its special hazards, they may not be what you fear. It is important to know ahead of time what you are risking and how to handle an emergency should one arise. The vast majority of potential or real accidents arise from the lack of common sense. We are not there to dominate or "use" the land, but to live in balance with nature around and within ourselves.

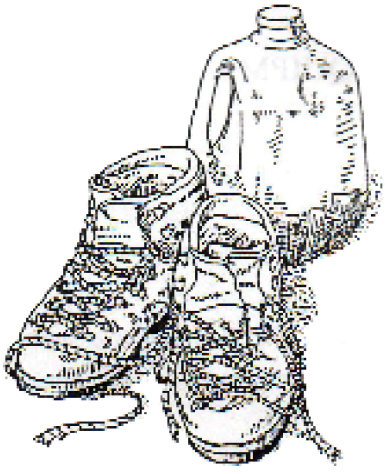
EQUIPMENT LIST

(Always check with your guides concerning specific equipment they require or suggest for the area you will be in.)

For solo time:

BACKPACK (self-inspected, well-fitting, and in good condition)
If you have never worn a backpack before, make sure the one you obtain fits you. Make certain the straps, webbing, frame, fittings, zippers, and pockets are in good repair. Make sure it is large enough to hold your gear. When packing, try to distribute weight evenly throughout the various sections. Get someone to help you adjust the shoulder and waist straps so they are comfortable. It is a good idea to walk around with your backpack on after you have packed it. Get used to it. Imagine its weight after a mile or two of hiking. Ideal weight is 35 pounds or less once packed.

SLEEPING BAG (effective to at least 0- 30 degrees F. depending on bioregion and time of year)



SLEEPING PAD (include a repair kit if it is inflatable)

GROUND CLOTH (for under sleeping bag)
A plastic ground cloth is suggested for use under your sleeping bag to protect against sharp rocks and pine needles, as well as water in case of rain. Nylon is rain permeable, so not suggested for this use.

STRONG NYLON or PLASTIC RAIN TARP (9x11) or TENT

It will be up to you whether you use a tarp or a tent as your shelter. Tarps can be used as a sun or wind shield, and a primitive tent in the event of rain. Six by nine feet is barely adequate. Nine by ten is adequate. You will want the lightest weight consistent with fabric strength. The wind eats up inadequate tarps. First the grommets tear away; then the fabric itself tears. Make sure the fabric is tough. Canvas is too heavy. Your guides will be pleased to show you a variety of ways in which tarps can be erected in the field, according to the terrain you will live in. If you bring a tent be sure it has a working rain fly.

SMALL CLASP KNIFE

Avoid sheath knives. They can stab you through the sheath. A small clasp knife (jackknife) will be adequate for the threshold time.

SEVERAL BANDANNAS

This is an essential, multi-purpose item. It can be a pot holder, a sun shield, a sponge, a rag, a mask against the blowing dust, a constricting band, a compress, a bandage, a handkerchief, a distress flag, a stonepile or solo-place marker, etc. Bright colors are better.

4 ONE-GALLON PLASTIC WATER CONTAINERS

One-gallon plastic milk or juice containers will do, but look something thicker if possible. You will carry one gallon of water for each day you are alone. You will need to drink at least three quarts per day. Your guides will make certain you are supplied with any additional water you might need. If you are flying to the location, water containers can most likely be purchased once you are there or sometimes provided by the guides.

TWO LARGE, ONE SMALL GARBAGE BAGS (see below for use)

The two large plastic bags (usually black) can be used during a storm. They provide an emergency poncho when arm and head holes are cut. They can be draped over your pack, stuffed with overflow equipment, or filled with dry kindling in case an emergency fire is needed to prevent hypothermia. The smaller bag is needed to store all garbage (used T.P., feminine items, etc.) so that it can more easily be disposed of when you return.

JOURNAL and PENCILS or PENS (multiple)

You may want to keep a journal so that you can recognize your own continued growth, long after your return. The insights that come during your participation are invaluable. A keystone of the human learning process is the ability of the student to *reflect,* to obtain meaningful feedback from past experience.

WARM WEATHER CLOTHING:

Shorts or lightweight long pants

Short or long-sleeve shirts

Light jacket (fleece is good), and heavier warm jacket ("puffy" is good)

COLD WEATHER CLOTHING:

Wool or fleece cap

Warm mittens or gloves

Base layer (thermal underwear), midweight layer (fleece), warm jacket

Warm socks (multiple pairs if they might get wet)

Rain boots if appropriate for the climate

100 FEET of ROPE (if using a tarp rather than a tent)

MATCHES (made watertight) or WATERPROOF MATCHES

HIKING SHOES or BOOTS (known to be comfortable and waterproof)

SMALL DAY PACK (to carry emergency kit, water, etc.)

RAINCOAT and RAINPANTS (rain boots too if suggested by climate)

1 or 2 ONE-QUART WATER BOTTLES (lots of people like SmartWater bottles since they can be easily held in a hand and are sturdy)

TOILET PAPER (non colored)

TOILETRIES

FLASHLIGHT (with extra batteries or solar panel)

SUN PROTECTION: CHAPSTICK (SPF-15 or higher), SUNSCREEN (SPF-30 or higher), SUNGLASSES (with UV block), SUN HAT

For Basecamp time:

- TENT (and ground cloth for beneath) or TARP
- CAMPING CHAIR
- EXTRA BLANKET (lightweight fleece or insulated work well)
- CUP, BOWL, UTENSILS
- STOVE AND FUEL
- COOKING POT(S)
- FOOD FOR YOURSELF (more for contributions to group meals if planned)
- COOLER &/OR CONTAINER FOR FOOD (tight against mice, etc.)
- TOWEL (and in some cases swimming suit)
- EXTRA CHANGE OF CLOTHES

Emergency Kit (to be taken wherever you go):

- AT LEAST 2 QUARTS OF WATER
- BANDANNA
- SUNSCREEN
- TOILET PAPER
- MATCHES (made watertight)
- SMALL CLASP KNIFE
- FLASHLIGHT (with extra batteries)
- A FEW BANDAIDS, TUBE OF ANTISEPTIC
- TUBE OF HONEY OR ENERGY BAR OR CANDY (for quick energy)
- WOOL/FLEECE CAP, JACKET (even if warm weather, as weather can change quickly)
- RAIN GEAR (if any slight chance of storm within 24 hours)
- EMERGENCY FIRST AID PROCEDURES CHECKLIST (see Appendix)
- CELL PHONE or OTHER GPS DEVICE (if you have concerns about whether to carry one of these devices please reach out to your guides)

Additions to Consider:

ELECTROLYTE POWDER

A large percentage of people who experience nausea, headache, and / or stomach troubles while fasting can find relief with electrolyte replacements. This now comes in powder and tablet form and can be found in camping stores, grocery stores, etc. Use a small amount in your daily water if needed. (Brands include LMNT, Sports Research, Liquid I.V., DripDrop, Gatorade, etc.).

BENADRYL or EPI-PEN (if prone to allergic reactions)

Anyone who is aware that they have a severe allergic reaction to insect bites (most commonly bees) is required to carry an adequate remedy from their personal doctor at all times.

FIBER PILLS or POWDER

Some people who are fasting may have difficulty with constipation, although this is rarely dangerous. If you have a history of this tendency, we suggest exploring the use of natural laxatives such as psyllium seed (often available as Metamucil) a day or two prior to your fast. It is very important to take several glasses of water with each dose, otherwise psyllium seed can have the opposite effect. Remember, drinking sufficient amounts of water while fasting can, in and of itself, help with this condition.

MUSICAL INSTRUMENT, CAMERA, ART SUPPLIES, etc.

A good question to ask is “what might I bring to help create a meaningful ceremony for myself, and what instead might be a distraction to avoid the fruitful silence?”

PRESCRIPTION DRUGS

If you are currently taking a **prescribed drug**, check with your doctor concerning its use during a fast and a time of aloneness, and follow your doctor’s advice. **You must also keep your guides closely informed regarding this matter. Food can be taken with your pills if needed. Do not discontinue prescribed drugs unless approved by your doctor.**

INSECT REPELLENT

POISON OAK RELIEF (if appropriate)

BEAR PROOF FOOD CONTAINERS (when in known bear country)

NEEDLE AND THREAD (and/or repair kits for inflatable sleeping pads and tents)

COMPASS

WHISTLE

HEAT EXHAUSTION

Precautions: Find or create shade and stay in it during the hottest hours of the day (11:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. depending on the time of the year). Keep your head covered with a hat or a damp bandanna. Take it easy. Drink water as often as you need to. Do not try to climb a mountain. Respect the power of the sun.

Symptoms: Pale, clammy skin, weakness, nausea, dizziness, tiredness, headache, possible fainting.

Treatment: Rest, shade, water, nightfall. A wet bandanna-hat. A sponge bath.

SUNBURN

Precautions: Always carry your sunscreen, sun hat, and sunglasses with you, even on a short walk.

The air is clear, the sun is hot, and there is reflected radiation from the stones or soil. Protect yourself by covering up and using a broad-spectrum sunscreen of your choice. A severe case of sunburn will produce oozing blisters, not an attractive tan. Watch your time in the sun. *Do not fall asleep in the nude.* If you experience chills and fever along with a severe burn, get in touch with basecamp.

DEHYDRATION

Precautions: If you are fasting, the most precious element you possess is water. During the threshold time you should be drinking three quarts a day, especially in dry climates. Desert winds desiccate. Hot air pulls moisture from your body whether you feel thirsty or not. You can live for weeks without food. Without water, in the heat, you have three days or less. **Do not hike anywhere without water.** Carry your container wherever you go. Water is not only the remedy for dehydration, but also a preventative medicine for altitude sickness, and both hypo/hyperthermia.

Symptoms: Weakness, exhaustion, dizziness, nausea.

Treatment: Drink water and rest in the shade. A wet bandanna-hat. Drink *more* water. Take a **reasonable** amount of electrolytes and/or salt.

EXPOSURE TO COLD

Precautions: Always carry with you a wool cap (even in the summer months), warm jacket, and a raincoat if there is any possibility of a storm moving in. Stay hydrated.

The weather can turn bitterly cold. The wind can rise like a monster with rain and sleet in its teeth. You must have clothes that will protect you from the dangers of excessive body heat loss (hypothermia): ample synthetic or down jackets, wool sweaters, socks, and caps. Remember that the greatest source of body heat loss is through the crown of your head. Mittens also cut down on heat loss. Remember that moderate exercise produces some body heat, but excessive exertion without food will expose you to the dangers of hypothermia or pneumonia. Maintain water use to prevent hypothermia.

Symptoms: Weakness, trembling, uncontrollable shaking, feelings of exhaustion, disorientation, lapsing into unconsciousness.

Treatment: Applied warmth, piled-on sleeping bags, use of body heat to warm the victim, taking measures to be sure the patient's body heat is rising, not allowing the person to sink into unconscious stupor. Look for frostbite. Warm frostbitten members gradually and carefully, to keep from destroying skin tissue. Return to basecamp.

LIGHTNING.

Lightning (and thunder) can be terrifying. Especially in the summer months, sudden and spectacular thunderstorms can occur. If you are in a high place, on a ridge, peak, or prominence, seek safety until the storm blows over. Get down low. Do not look for shelter under tall trees, prominent boulders, jutting outcroppings, or caves.

FLASH FLOODS.

Sudden and devastating, they do not always occur with a warning. It is always best to sleep *above* a place where water has obviously coursed through in the past. Consult with your guides regarding flash flood conditions.

FLORA AND FAUNA

One of the tragic losses humans have sustained is their ability to converse with wild animals and plants. Alone during your initiation ceremony you have the opportunity to use this atrophied limb of the human spirit. Nevertheless, there are a few animals whose companionship you might want to be careful about.

Few creatures or plants in the wild can harm you and none will if you stay out of their way. You are the stranger, the guest, in their home. They are more aware of you than you can imagine. A few items of information will help you to understand their habits and habitat.

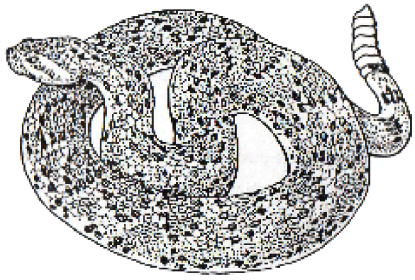
LARGE ANIMALS

Large animals you may encounter (depending on where your solo time takes place) include bears, elk, and moose. If you are in bear country, remember that bears have been known to react unpredictably to the stimulus of the presence of food and the odor of it (and perhaps other human odors as well). If you should meet up with Bear, by day or night, a loud, moving, aggressive, defensive posture (i.e., agitated yelling, banging, thrashing, screaming) will almost always drive the bear away. If Bear persists, leave your camp and make your way to basecamp or to your buddy. If Bear shows up at night, make certain you have an emergency kit (with flashlight) and warm clothes close by. You may wind up spending the night away from your place. Other more common, though rarely seen, large animals are **mountain lions, bobcats, fox, and coyotes**, who are furtive and will not harm you if you maintain your balance in their territory.

On some public land (Forestry and BLM) ranchers have permission to graze **range cattle**. Best to keep your distance, and to be aware that if you choose your solo spot in a nice meadow area where grazing is permitted, you might find yourself sharing your spot with a few curious cattle.

SNAKES

You may encounter many kinds of snake, but only a few are poisonous. The most common poisonous snake to be found anywhere in the American continent is the rattlesnake. If you see one, consider it a privilege. Rattlesnake is trying to tell you something. Ordinarily they would not want to be seen by you. The rattling of theirtail is not only a warning to keep your



distance, but is also an expression of their own fear of you. Certainly, you are not their prey.

You are most likely to see rattlers in the spring, summer and fall, when outside temperatures are

agreeable to their blood temperature. In the cold winter, you rarely see them, for they are deep in the earth, hibernating with all their relatives. On hot days, they snooze in cool, dappled shade. On hot nights, they hunt. When the weather is cool, they tend to be sluggish. Rattlers do not make or live in holes in the earth. They seek fissures and deep cracks between stones, or cool places under piles of dead wood. You might be most likely to encounter a fully alert rattlesnake in the morning or evening, when the temperature best suits their reptilian requirements.

Snakebite precautions: Simply be clear headed about where you are stepping, reaching, or sitting. If you are climbing a steep place and reach up for a handhold, make sure the ledge is unoccupied before you grab. Do not run through the sage, underbrush, or high grasses. Be aware of where you're walking.

Symptoms: Often there is no envenomation. If the rattler actually envenomates you: rapid swelling locally and in lymph nodes, pain, discoloration of skin, weakness, rapid pulse, dimness of vision, shock.

Treatment: The old snakebite kits which contain a razor for cutting and a small, inadequate suction cup are no longer recommended. Also do not use a constricting band.

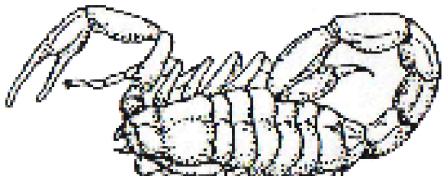
If you are bitten by a rattlesnake, try to stay as calm as possible, given the circumstances. Clean out the wound with soap and/or water. Remove any constrictive jewelry or other items. Do not accidentally introduce the venom into your system by sucking on the bite. Do nothing to speed up the flow of venom through the lymph system.

Notify your buddy as soon as possible or return to basecamp, whichever is closer. If you are alone and a long way from help, relax. Return to basecamp slowly if you are able.

Whatever your situation, you can be assured that the pain will grow over an hour or so. The bitten part will swell and turn purple, even black. The pain will be intense but not necessarily impossible to bear. The chances are that your body will assimilate the poison and that within 24 hours you will feel well enough to walk out. Remember that a very small percentage of all who are bitten by rattlesnakes actually die.

SCORPIONS

SOLB Vision Fast Handbook



Scorpion is a difficult critter to like. The little stinger on theirtail can inflict a painful disagreeable sting. Though this sting is seldom fatal, it is a trial to be endured, especially if one is alone.

Scorpions exist almost anywhere. We do not ordinarily see them because they are active at night, especially when the weather is warm and the night is dark. By day, they rest under rocks and in cold, moist, hidden places and are quite inactive. By night, they hunt, not human beings, but small insects and spiders.

Precautions: Shake out your shoes and clothing just to make sure Scorpion has not tiptoed in at dawn, hoping to spend a quiet day in the shade. You might also look for them under your ground cloth or in a pile of wood. When getting up at night, put your shoes on before walking away from your sleeping bag.

Treatment: Use cool or wet compresses. Return to basecamp so that your guides can monitor your condition and determine if you need to visit a hospital. There is a wide range of species, some with dangerous venom and some with just an innocuous sting.

BEES, WASPS, AND OTHER INSECTS

If you are allergic to bee or wasp stings, you must inform your guides before you participate, and carry benadryl and your own Epipen at all times. Otherwise, if stung, you would use the same treatment as for scorpion sting.

There are a few poisonous spiders (the Black Widow and Brown Recluse as examples) that are rarely seen, yet a part of many eco-systems. Mostly they seek dark, hidden places. Be cautious about putting your hand into dark holes, or entering caves without a flashlight. If you experience a bite that is painful, and not sure how you got it (or actually saw an unidentified spider that may have inflicted the bite), return to basecamp to have it checked out.

TARANTULAS

Harmless giant spiders of the desert, Tarantula poses no threat in the American Southwest. They avoid humans, as most critters do. If you should meet one, stop and talk a while. They are most likely to be

seen in the Fall - their mating season. Treatment for this non-venomous variety would be the same as for Scorpion. Come to basecamp and check for any adverse reactions.

TARANTULA HAWK

SOLB Vision Fast Handbook



Tarantula hawks are neither tarantulas nor hawks, but rather a large wasp (up to 2.5 in) that preys on tarantulas. They are docile and will rarely sting unless stepped on. The pain of a sting is said to be excruciating, but only lasts for about five minutes. Aside from the possibility of triggering an allergic reaction, the sting is not dangerous and does not require medical attention. However, Local redness appears in most cases and lasts for up to a week.

POISONOUS PLANTS

If you are fasting, you might find yourself tempted by what appears to be edible plant life. Please do not attempt to eat anything, even if you think you know what it is.

POISON OAK, IVY, SUMAC

Make sure you can identify these plants and then take special care to avoid them. If you are in the range of these quite "irritating" plants, consider bringing along some of the newer treatments such as Tecnu (over the counter), and an extra change of clothes if you've wandered too close. Most likely your guides will provide some form of treatment at basecamp.

CACTI



Merely a slight brush against several species of cacti will result in some pain and difficulty in removing the spines. Cholla spines are hooked at the tips and are not easily removed from the skin. A comb works best -- so as not to reattach the cholla spines to your fingers as you pull them out. Exercise caution when you walk about in the dark. Keep your boots on.



THE TERRAIN

Wilderness terrain can be deceptive to a city or suburb dweller. It can

also be dangerous if one is not fully aware of where or how one is going. A mile in the wilderness is worth two in the city. What appears to be a level horizon turns out to be more up and down than flat. Do not extend yourself beyond your physical capabilities and conditioning, especially if you are not eating. A fast can leave you light-headed, clumsy-footed, and often weaker than you realized.

CLIFFS, CANYON WALLS, SLIDES, DROP-OFFS, ETC.

Falls and fractures are often caused by people hiking where even bighorn sheep fear to tread. Many a mountain hiker has scrambled up a place impossible to get back down from, or misjudged distance from the edge of a sheer canyon wall. Slides (steep slopes covered with loose boulders) are particularly dangerous. Rocks kicked into motion cause landslides. Landslides fall on others or on you.

THICK FORESTS

Thickly-forested areas are easy places in which to get lost. Without conspicuous landmarks to use as points of reference, you can easily become disoriented. The best precaution is to stay out of densely forested areas, or be well familiar with the use of a compass.

DISORIENTATION

Many participants have at least temporarily become lost. Either they have trouble finding their stonepile (see "Stonepile") or their own place, or even basecamp. It does help to familiarize yourself with the lay of the land, to be clear ahead of time about how to find your way - before you step across the threshold.

The panic one feels at being lost can either disable you or enable you to think creatively about your predicament. Actually, you are not lost. Your general whereabouts are known. After a while, the way back or the way out of this mess will dawn on you. If there is a high point nearby, climb it to get a bigger perspective. See if you can retrace your bootprints. Even if you have no water (you forgot to take it with you on your hike), by resting in the shade and not moving around, you can last at least three days.

By orienting yourself to the four directions (north, south, east and west) you will not only insure your chances of not getting lost, but you will be performing an ancient ceremonial way of orienting yourself to the universe.

EMERGENCIES AND SAFETY PROCEDURES

You have sources of help. One is your buddy; another is basecamp; another is the nearest travelled road.

If you cannot reach any of these, then you must wait. If your buddy cannot find you, they will notify basecamp and a general search will be conducted. You need merely wait and care for yourself until rescue comes. It is difficult to wait, but it is necessary. If your injury permits it, or otherwise provide for your own comfort. If you can move without further hurting yourself, proceed to the nearest source of help.

EMERGENCY CALL: *THREE BLASTS, CALLS, WHISTLES,* OR *DRUM BEATS, ETC.,* IN *A ROW, A PAUSE, THEN THREE MORE, AND* CONTINUE *ON UNTIL FOUND.*

Emergency First Aid. It is impossible in limited space to cover the seemingly endless variety of possible emergency situations that might arise. The following are the very basic instructions that underlie much of the discussion of first aid and emergency procedures in the preparatory meetings.

1. You cannot properly diagnose the injuries of a person who is unconscious - unless certain signs guarantee the nature of the injury. If you do not know what is the matter, you cannot properly treat your buddy, or perhaps, even move them safely. You must seek help.

2. If there are obvious signs that you must do something fast or it will all be over, such as giving mouth to mouth resuscitation or stopping the bleeding, please consider doing it.

3. There are ways to help a person who is in shock, even if that person is unconscious. All care must be taken to maintain normal body temperature. If the unconscious buddy is lying in the hot sun, then cool shade must be erected. If the buddy is exposed to the numbing wind or cool rain, then they must be kept warm and reasonably dry.

PHYSICAL PREPARATION

GETTING IN SHAPE. Sleep and moderate exercise are an important part of your physical preparedness.

DIET. One month before you arriveafter the Day Walk has been completed (see Day Walk), you might begin to watch your diet more carefully, cutting down on beef, pork, and other heavy or oily forms of

meat protein, substituting more cereals and grains -- in short, balancing the diet and not overeating. It is suggested that you also begin to drink more fluids and juices and eat more soups and stews. Gradually, you will be cleansing your body by flushing it out, keeping your digestive tract in balance by training it to go on less. Do not, however, overdo it. Come to the threshold healthy and strong.

MENSTRUATION. The experience of the vision fast often brings on menstruation ahead of schedule. Some realize beforehand that this special time of the month will fall during the time they are in the sacred world of the threshold. They may look forward to their moon, for it is a time of power, of heightened intuition, and attunement to the spiritual heart of the earth.

Menstration can enact the cycles of the earth and sky, sun and water, as the tides of the ocean wash through. This is an opportunity to offer blood to the land with thanksgiving,

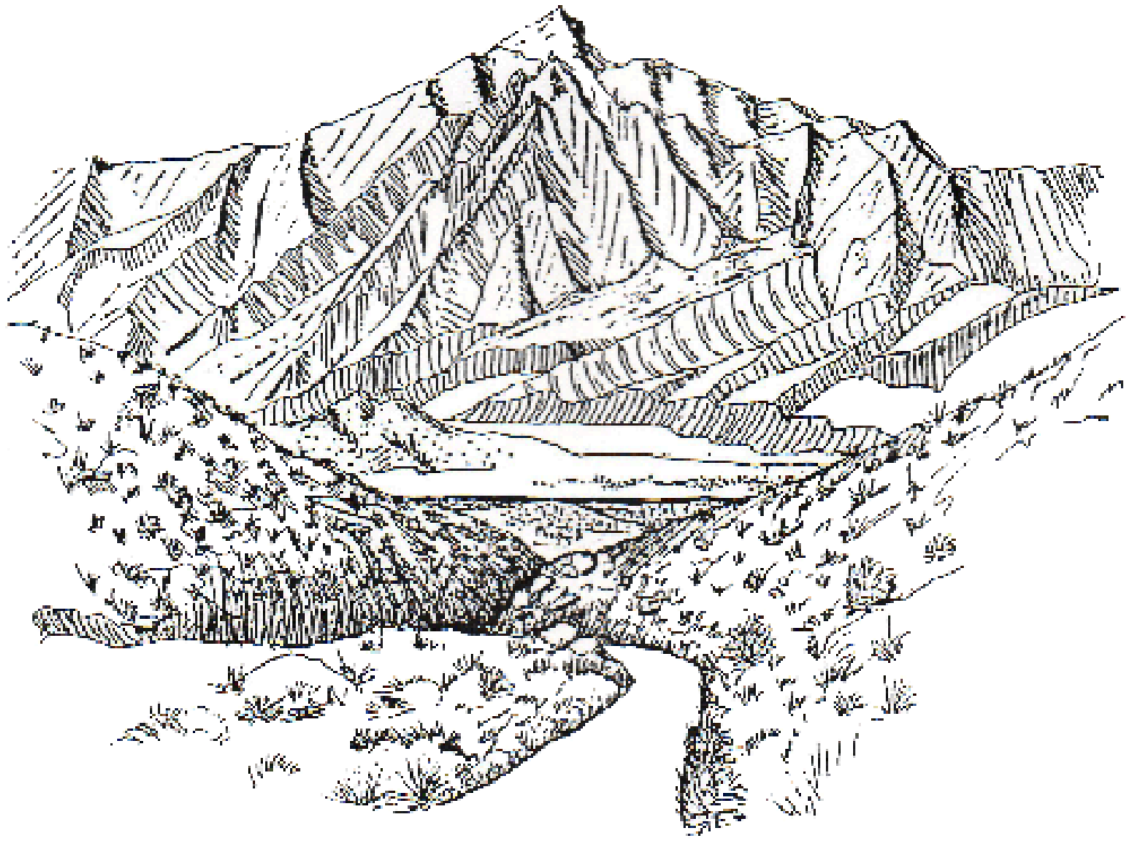
APPENDIX

RETURNING EARLY FROM THE THRESHOLD TIME

GOING ON YOUR OWN

FEES AND PAYMENTS

WILDERNESS ETHICS STATEMENT



RETURNING EARLY FROM THE THRESHOLD TIME

Does returning before the threshold time is over mean that you have failed? On the contrary, **there is no success or failure in the self-measurement of this ceremony**. Because of your threshold experiences you may have acquired a greater clarity in terms of your picture of yourself than those who do not return early. It may be that you returned at precisely the right moment in order to nourish yourself or survive, to get the understanding you needed, and to continue your growth.

There are many good reasons for returning early. Foremost among these reasons is your own personal assessment of your health, mental condition and spiritual well-being. Do not allow yourself to be caught in the trap of being afraid to terminate what you set out to do if your self-concept says otherwise.

"Gutting it out" may only make it worse. Many have spoken of the fear that others might "look down on them" if they came back early. Remember that it takes courage to act against peer pressure. This is not the first, or the last time, that you will have to face this fear.

Your guides will welcome you back and help you define clearly for yourself and others why you decided to return, and what lessons you have learned from participating the way you have in the ceremony.

FEES AND PAYMENTS

To speak of money is an exercise in humility. We need money to survive, to eat, to feel secure and cared for, and yet, money carries the weight of many shadows – greed, consumerism, and commodification. Living in a time where too often wealth equates with power, where those with less are viewed as less than, and where shrewdness is valued over relationship, this comes as no surprise. Our society is obsessed with money, and so we, at the School of Lost Borders, walk as consciously as possible whenever we enter into this realm.

Since the inception of the School, over forty five years ago, it has been our commitment to keep our programs accessible to anyone who feels a strong intention to participate. We recognize that inequities, due to systemic oppression, create disparities in access to our programs. Thus, our bottom line is to never turn away anyone from our programs.

We at Lost Borders are doing what we can to face inequity. This is an ongoing, evolving process. We have a sliding scale, scholarships, and payment plans to help make our programs as accessible as possible. And we ask that those of financial means or access to wealth pay more, inviting an inquiry into the realities of

systemic wealth inequality as they consider what feels right to offer. We also encourage participants to seek support through crowdfunding and community engagement, not only because it can help generate the resources needed, but because it weaves a fabric of personal and community investment in one's experience. This also promotes a sense of reciprocity between the School, participants, and the communities that our participants serve.

In order to remain a viable organization, we need money to support our guides and administration, as well as pay the multitude of expenses that go into running a wilderness-based non-profit. To us, the very practical things we need in order to support our work, such as insurance, permits, and propane, are considered sacred, as we cannot hold the ceremony without them.

We are not a charity organization. Nor are we a foundation. We are a small non-profit organization with a very modest budget. But, really, we are not that either. Rather, we are a group of ordinary people who just happen to have an insatiable passion – a calling, perhaps – for taking people out on the land as a means for bringing about community and personal transformation.

We have witnessed again and again the life-changing power of the wilderness rites of passage ceremony, and for this reason, we are committed to making our programs accessible to all who feel called.

WILDERNESS ETHICS STATEMENT

These guidelines and aspirations are based on respect and reverence for the Earth and on our recognition of the many dimensions of relationship between human visitors and living wilderness areas. Our being in natural and wild places is a gift which we honor by doing our best to live lightly, leave no trace, support the preservation and protection of the Earth, and, when possible, help renew the places we visit. We see these attitudes and actions not as sacrifices but as opportunities to express our gratitude in skillful and meaningful ways and as opportunities to learn how to live better through the teachings of the Earth. Because our trips go to several different ecosystems—high desert, canyon country, mountain forests—we adapt our ethics and actions to the particular needs of the place.

- We acknowledge the original people of the lands that we work on and look to give back to them in some way, where possible.
- We attend to our attitudes and behaviors in the places we visit. We work to be mindful of our impacts on the ecosystem, soil, water, plants, and wildlife of the areas we visit. We do our best to understand their ways, rhythms, needs, and systems because understanding supports responsible and caring action.
- We practice Leave-No-Trace camping as appropriate for each bioregion we visit.
- We keep our groups small for the sake of safety and to reduce our impacts on the land.
- When traveling to, from, and in wilderness areas, we choose routes that will cause the least damage. We keep vehicles on established roads and ways, and we walk on the most durable surfaces. We take special care to avoid damaging cryptobiotic soil and to avoid eroding stream banks.
- We select basecamp sites that will not show lasting signs of our presence. In desert and canyon areas, we do our best to set up basecamps on rock. We give our sites enough time to recover between visits so they show no cumulative signs of our use. When necessary, we coordinate our visits with other groups to avoid overuse.
- When we do have fires, we keep them small, using dead and down wood (in forested areas), or bring in our own (in desert and canyon areas). We use a fire pan, mound, or other method to avoid scarring rocks or soil. We either carry out our ashes or scatter them widely.
- We use stoves for cooking. If fire danger is high or fires are not permitted, we do not have fires.
- We recognize the fragility of water sources in all wilderness areas and take care not to pollute or damage them. In arid places, we avoid water sources for our camps in order not to inhibit wildlife who depend on scarce water. We do not wash ourselves or dishes near water sources.

- We pack out all our trash. We use the most appropriate and least impactful method for dealing with human waste. Usually this means using a self-contained portable toilet (such as Eco-Safe) in basecamp. We carry out all our toilet paper, tampons, etc. We work to keep ourselves current on the best ways of disposing of human waste and to apply those ways.
- We do our best to remove evidence of our impacts when we leave. This can include erasing our footpaths, replacing any rocks we have disturbed, raking the area, and sprinkling leaves, twigs, and branches to naturalize areas we have used. We remove all signs of our visit such as markers for the buddy system, altars, purpose circles, and rock cairns we have built. We do not disturb historical rock cairns. If there are anthropological sites nearby, we do not disturb them.
- We work with appropriate land-stewards, landowners and land managers for the areas we visit to ensure compliance with regulations and to foster good on-going relationships.
- We understand that meaning well is not enough, so we work to educate ourselves about wilderness ethics. This statement of our ethics is a work-in-progress, which will change as we learn more.